Ryan McWay

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Summary

Applied economist and Ph.D. candidate with 6+ years of experience evaluating policy and program impact using causal inference, machine learning, and large-scale survey and administrative data. Led a government-partnered national education evaluation in Morocco and a randomized trial of an AI tutoring platform in Jordan. Proficient in Python, R, Stata, and SQL.

Professional Experience

J-PAL Dec. 2024 – Present
Principal Investigator | Morocco Innovation and Evaluation Lab *Remote*
- Lead the impact evaluation of Morocco's national Pioneer School Program, a reform that scaled from 626 to 4,626 schools, analyzing administrative records on roughly 24 million student observations and original assessments of 36,000+ students in 483 schools.
- Designed a matched-pair difference-in-differences analysis using machine-learning variable selection (LASSO); found learning gains of 0.6 standard deviations, among the largest effects in comparable evaluations, and identified implementation factors that weakened results at scale.

J-PAL Aug. 2025 – Present
Research Associate | American University of Cairo *Remote*
- Co-lead a pre-registered randomized trial of an AI-enabled personalized math platform for grade-6 students in Jordan, measuring effects on math achievement, self-efficacy, and anxiety; study accepted at Stage 1 of a registered report at the *Journal of Development Economics*.

University of Minnesota Aug. 2026 – Dec. 2026
Research Assistant | Regional Sustainable Development Partnerships *Saint Paul, MN*
- Partnered with the Minnesota Forest Resource Center (MFRC) to reveal non-market valuation of forest related services.

University of Michigan Mar. 2025 – Dec. 2025
Research Associate | Ross School of Business *Remote*
- Collected data and prepared data analysis for a meta analysis of universal basic income (UBI) studies.

Minnesota Pollution Control Agency Jan. 2025 – May 2025
Research Assistant *Saint Paul, MN*
- Lead the curation and construction of the Minnesota Economic Analysis Guide to guide internal economic analysis related to the Minnesota Climate Action Framework

University of Michigan Jun. 2020 – Aug. 2022
Research Area Specialist Associate | Population Studies Center *Ann Arbor, MI*
- Lead a team of research assistants and field operators to implement two separate impact evaluations in Mozambique.

University of San Francisco Feb. 2019 – Aug. 2020
Research Assistant | Economics Department *San Francisco, CA*
- Contributed to a working paper on sectoral effects and a potential environmental poverty trap created by tornadoes in the United States.

BRAC May 2019 – Aug. 2019
Research Intern | Independent Evaluation and Research Center *Kampala, Uganda*
- Supported two randomized trials in Uganda: the endline study of the Ultra Poor Graduation (youth focus) program and the baseline study of Strong Minds, a mental health and adolescent empowerment program.

Education

University of Minnesota Saint Paul, MN
Ph.D. in Applied Economics *Expected May 2027*

University of Minnesota Saint Paul, MN
M.S. in Applied Economics *2026*

University of San Francisco San Francisco, CA
M.S. in International and Development Economics *May 2020*

Saint Louis University Saint Louis, MO
B.S. in Economics *May 2018*
B.S. in International Business

Selected Research

1. *Scaling Education Reform: Evidence from Morocco's Pioneer School Program*, joint with Paul Glewwe, Mridul Joshi, et al. Working paper.
2. *Regenerative Agriculture and Farmer Profitability: Modeling Adoption for Scalable Climate Mitigation.* Working paper.
3. *Impact Evaluation of the Darsel Math Personalized Learning Platform in Jordan*, joint with Caroline Krafft, Paul Glewwe, et al. **Journal of Development Economics**. Stage 1 Conditionally Accepted. Link
4. *Comparing Human-Only, AI-Assisted, and AI-Led Teams on Assessing Research Reproducibility in Quantitative Social Science*, joint with Abel Brodeur, et al. **Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences**. Forthcoming. Link
5. *Computational Reproducibility and Robustness of Some Economics and Political Science Research*, joint with Abel Brodeur, et al. **Nature**. Forthcoming. Link

Skills

Programming & Analytics:	Python | R | Stata | SQL | Earth Engine | ArcGIS
Methods:	Causal Inference | Econometrics | Machine Learning | Impact Evaluation
Visualization & Tools:	Tableau | Git | LaTeX | Microsoft Office Suite
Survey Design & Fieldwork:	ODK | SurveyCTO | Qualtrics | Household, Phone, and Digital Surveys
Financial Data:	Bloomberg Market Concepts | Thomson Reuters Eikon
Languages:	Italian (Conversant) | Latin (Proficient) | Portuguese (Beginner) | Spanish (Beginner)

Recognitions

2024	Graduate Scholar – Institute on the Environment (IonE), University of Minnesota
2024	Graduate Fellowship – Center for International Food and Agricultural Policy, University of Minnesota
2022	CF Future Leaders of Production Agriculture and Marketing Fellowship
2021	Irving Fisher Graduate Research Paper Prize
2020	Jacques Artus Award, Outstanding Thesis